

DECODED EXPLAINED

14 July, 2026

Topics we are going to discuss today

1. Can **Biogas** Aid India's Energy Security? - **GS 3**
2. Vulnerabilities in the **UMANG portal**. - **GS 2**
3. Supreme Court has constituted four **special benches** - **GS 2**
4. Supreme Court has raised serious concerns about growing **misuse of** the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (**POCSO**) Act 2012. - **GS 2**
5. **Vietnam** - **GS 2**
6. **Migration trend** in India - **GS 1**

Can biogas aid India's energy security?

India, which imports nearly 85% of its crude oil needs, remains vulnerable to global energy shocks. Over the years, it has pushed several initiatives to promote compressed biogas. Despite these efforts, progress has been limited: government support and incentives could provide a boost to the sector

EXPLAINER

V. Nivedita

Tensions in West Asia continue to keep global energy markets on edge. India imports nearly 85% of its crude oil needs, much of it from West Asia, and supplies faced disruptions due to the Israel-U.S.-Iran war. While the government has diversified its crude oil suppliers, around 90% of India's LPG imports still transit through the Strait of Hormuz, making any instability in the region a potential risk to India's energy security.

Over the years, India has pushed several initiatives to promote alternate fuels like compressed biogas to reduce dependence on imported fuel, tackle agricultural waste and support rural incomes. But despite ambitious targets and policy support, progress has remained limited.

The search for an alternative fuel

Biogas is a mixture of methane, CO₂ and small quantities of other gases produced by anaerobic digestion of organic matter. It can be processed and compressed to get **Compressed Biogas (CBG)**. It is chemically identical to CNG, renewable, carbon-neutral and can be produced from waste. It can be used directly to produce electricity, heating or as an energy source for cooking.

India has also been trying to blend biogas into its gas supply for at least a decade. The push gathered pace in 2018, when the Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation (SATAT) initiative was launched with a target of establishing 5,000 plants by 2023. Only 132 are completed as of June 3, 2026.

The Centre launched the **GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan)** scheme to increase CBG production. Under this 'waste to wealth' programme, the government offered grants of up to ₹50 lakh per district for



A biogas plant at the Waste-to-Energy unit in Koramangala in Bengaluru. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

community biogas plants. ₹564 crore was earmarked for the purchase of biomass collection machinery, while ₹994 crore was allocated to build pipelines connecting biogas plants directly to the gas grid.

However, progress on the ground has remained limited. The lack of infrastructure, poor private investment, difficulties in accessing formal credit and high upfront cost of technologies have stalled progress. Financial support from the government can make biogas projects economically viable. Other incentives, like accelerated depreciation and tax holidays, would also help attract private players.

Impact on cultivation patterns

The development of biogas has been uneven across the world, with Europe, China and the United States accounting for 90% of global production.

Germany is one of the largest producers in Europe, along with France, Denmark and the U.K. The fillip for the sector came in 2000, when Germany introduced the Renewable Energy Sources Act to incentivise production.

Over the years, it introduced schemes to guarantee income to producers, gave bonuses to help operators increase their income and encouraged small-scale biogas plants. However, the country's push for biogas triggered a "corn mania", with maize cultivation rising sharply because it was highly profitable for farmers. Maize slowly started to replace other food crops. Over a decade later, the government was forced to step in and control this by introducing a cap on the use of maize in biogas plants.

This danger hits close to home. The Economic Survey 2026 noted that maize cultivation in India has increased sharply, potentially affecting crop diversity and food security. It noted that while the national maize yield increased from approximately 2.56 tonnes per hectare in FY16 to roughly 3.78 tonnes per hectare by FY25, the yields for soybeans, sunflower, rapeseed, peanuts and millets, among other crops, have either stagnated or declined.

While this trend could be attributed to technological advancements, ethanol pricing can be an important factor.

The government fixes administered

per-litre ethanol prices based on the feedstock used. The price for maize-based ethanol is higher, while the price for rice-based ethanol is lower. The price for molasses-based ethanol is fixed between the two. Between FY22 and FY25, the administered price of maize-based ethanol grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 11.7%, making maize more lucrative for farmers.

While maize's area under cultivation and production jumped between FY22 and FY25, pulses output declined, while oilseeds and other cereals registered only modest growth.

India imports large quantities of pulses and edible oils to meet demand. Yet, instead of focussing on increasing production, the government's policy might inadvertently disincentivise farmers from cultivating them. Over time, this could increase India's dependence on imports and expose domestic food prices to greater volatility during supply shocks.

Denmark, which is targeting to use only biomethane in its gas system by 2030, offers a solution. The government discouraged the use of crops as feedstock, and the primary source is livestock manure and agricultural waste.

Government's action plan

In 2023, the National Biofuels Coordination Committee approved a mandatory blending obligation. Gas distributors have been mandated to blend CBG into their supply from FY26. It would start at 1% and rise to 5% by FY29. In her Budget speech in February 2024, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the phased blending of CBG in CNG for transport and Piped Natural Gas for domestic purposes "will be mandated".

To meet these targets, the government is ramping up the establishment of plants.

The question is whether the government can replicate India's ethanol blending programme with CBG. In 2014, just 1.5% of petrol was blended with ethanol. By December 2025, it had hit 20%, five years ahead of the original 2030 target.

THE GIST

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Can Biogas Aid India's Energy Security?

What the article is about

Whether India can use compressed biogas to reduce its dependence on imported oil and gas, and what could go wrong if it copies the "grow crops for fuel" approach.

What is biogas ?

Biogas is a renewable fuel created by breaking down organic waste without oxygen (anaerobic). Microorganisms decompose this material inside an airtight tank. This process produces a methane-rich gas used for heat and electricity,

- **Aerobic processes** require oxygen to produce energy, while
- **Anaerobic processes** produce energy without oxygen

Compressed Biogas (CBG)

Raw biogas made from waste cannot be used in vehicles right away. It is dirty, weak, and contains too many impurities. To turn it into a powerful fuel called CBG, it must go through two main steps:

1. **Upgrading (Cleaning the Gas)** - Impurities are stripped away
2. **Compression (Squeezing the Gas)**- Packed safely into metal **gas cylinders**, ready to be used in cars ,buses etc.

The **CBG is chemically identical to CNG** , Because it's chemically the same, CBG can be used anywhere CNG is used, without needing new engines or new pipelines.

Why biogas counts as green ?

- The CO₂ released when biogas burns is roughly the same CO₂ that would have escaped from rotting organic waste , so it **adds very little net new carbon** to the atmosphere.
Unlike fossil fuel
- Made from waste , **solves a waste-disposal problem** while creating fuel.

Two Government Schemes

SATAT (2018)

- SATAT stands for **Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation.**
- Comes under **Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas**
- **Goal** of setting up **5,000 CBG plants by 2023**, producing 15 million tonnes of CBG every year.
- But only 132 plants were actually completed by 2026

GOBARdhan (2018)

- GOBARdhan stands for **Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan**. (Galvanising" means activating)
- It was launched in 2018, under the **Swachh Bharat Mission**, idea is to convert cattle dung and farm/organic waste into biogas
- Nodal agency - **Ministry of Jal Shakti**

Why Hasn't This Worked Well?

- Lack of infrastructure
- Poor investment
- High upfront technology cost
- Difficulty accessing formal credit

Learning From the World

- Europe, China, and the United States together produce 90% of the world's biogas.

Germany's Mistake

- It passed the **Renewable Energy Sources Act in 2000**
- Growing **maize** (corn) for biogas was far more profitable than growing food crops for farmers
- It affected food security and Over a decade later, the German government had to step in and cap how much maize biogas plants could use, to protect food crop diversity. **Problem shifted from energy security to food security**

Denmark's Smarter Model

- Discourages using **food crops** as feedstock. There was a **cap limit**
- Denmark's biogas mainly comes from livestock manure and agricultural waste
- This **avoids the food-vs-fuel conflict** Germany ran into.

The Warning in the Economic Survey 2026

- This isn't really about biogas directly ,But the article uses it as a warning sign of what could happen with biogas too.
- The **government sets high administered prices for Maize-based ethanol**.This steadily rising, government-guaranteed price made maize the most lucrative crop for farmers to grow , exactly the same dynamic that caused Germany's corn mania.
- India's own **Economic Survey 2026 flagged that maize cultivation has been rising sharply, and this could hurt crop diversity and food security**

Benefits of CBG

- **Energy security** / import substitution.
- Rural **income** and employment. Farmers **earn from selling crop residue** and dung
- Agricultural-waste and **stubble management**. CBG uses paddy straw and other residues that are otherwise burned, It reduce air pollution probelm
- **Bio-manure by-product** ,is a nutrient-rich organic fertiliser that **reduces chemical-fertiliser** dependence and **improves soil health**
- **Waste to wealth,aligning with the circular-economy idea**

CHALLENGES

- Massive SATAT shortfall: only 133 of 5,000 targeted plants
- Infrastructure gaps:
- Weak credit access and high upfront cost
- Food-security risk

Way Forward

- Cap on food-crop feedstock
- Make manure and agricultural/organic waste the primary feedstock
- Access to credit
- Government support to fill the infrastructure gap
- Encourage private participation

User data exposed due to flaws in UMANG portal: researchers

UAN of PF subscribers, LPG booking details, and Aadhaar numbers among the exposed data: IT Ministry acknowledges vulnerabilities, says necessary measures are being implemented; initial fixes do nothing to fix the system, says researcher

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Multiple vulnerabilities in the UMANG, or Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance, portal that aggregates hundreds of public services offered by the Union and State governments are leaving data of potentially millions of Indians exposed across a variety of databases, including those from the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO), according to two security researchers who shared their findings with *The Hindu*.

The vulnerabilities, which have likely existed for years, affect several services tested on the UMANG portal, which has onboarded over 2,400 services. It stems from the architecture of the portal itself, said the researchers, Akshay C.S. and Viral Vaghela. "Almost everything is broken by design," Mr. Vaghela said.

The data exposed included Unique Account Numbers (UAN) with the EPFO, LPG cylinder booking details with at least one major oil marketing com-

Data at risk

Vulnerabilities in the UMANG portal are exposing user data across hundreds of services, including UAN cards, according to researchers

- Apart from UAN, details of LPG cylinder bookings and Aadhaar numbers have been exposed
- The EPFO module alone has been used over 40 crore times in the last three months; shortly after the vulnerabilities were reported, the main EPFO portal was taken down for "migration"
- The IT Ministry's initial fix has not completely shut off the flaws, over a month after vulnerabilities were reported to the government, the researchers say



pany, and Aadhaar numbers across several services where a user's ID details are saved. The Aadhaar numbers were found across many services in plain text, though such storage is disallowed by the Aadhaar Act, 2016. The Aadhaar module itself within UMANG was not vulnerable.

The EPFO module is UMANG's most-used service, recording over 40 crore transactions over the past three months.

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology acknowledged the vulnerabilities in a

statement to *The Hindu*. "Our development and security teams have carefully examined the observations and are implementing the necessary corrective and preventive measures," the Ministry said. "The plaintext information in the concerned APIs has been appropriately encrypted."

API review

The Ministry added that it has "reviewed the API transaction logs for the past three months" and found that "transaction volumes" were consistent and that it continued to keep a watch on activities on the

UMANG portal.

The Hindu is withholding the precise technical details of the vulnerabilities, as they remain active despite the above interventions. The encryption the IT Ministry referred to is "flawed and inadequate", Mr. Akshay said, adding that a simple workaround allowed it to be cracked anyway. At *The Hindu*'s request, the researchers shared their findings with Karan Saini, another independent security researcher, who termed the vulnerabilities "significant".

"Considering that rate limiting was implemented and the large number-space of EPFO UANs, it is unlikely that the vulnerability could have been exploited to mirror the entire EPFO database," Mr. Saini said, referring to the steps taken by the site to limit the number of requests a user can make. Still, he added, it "could potentially have been abused by cybercriminals in possession of UANs to siphon funds at scale by allowing for both changing of bank account details and initiating payouts, which is very concerning".

"The fixes initially im-

plemented following the disclosure appear to do nothing to secure the system and instead confuse obscurity with security, while also introducing another vulnerability in the process," Mr. Saini said.

Mr. Akshay and Mr. Vaghela reported both vulnerabilities to the IT Ministry and the Computer Emergency Response Team, India (CERT-In), which issues alerts and helps organisations across the country with fixes for vulnerabilities like these. Shortly after the pair reported the vulnerabilities, the EPFO took down its online portal for a "migration", and some services remained unavailable this week.

The researchers said they suspected this was in response to their alerts, which were also sent to the organisation. The Ministry of Labour and Employment did not respond to a request for comment.

"It is worth examining whether the fixes deployed on the UMANG portal were simultaneously deployed across the services for which UMANG acts as a proxy," Mr. Saini said.

Context

Recently, researchers revealed significant vulnerabilities in the UMANG portal.

About UMANG Portal

- UMANG (**Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance**) is a single unified platform to access government services offered by **Central, State, and Local bodies**, anytime, anywhere
- It is part of the Digital India initiative of the **Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY)**

Significance of UMANG

- **Promotes citizen-centric digital governance**
- Improves **access to public services**
- Enhances **transparency**.
- Improves **accountability**
- Supports **Ease of Living**
- **Strengthens Digital India ecosystem**

Issues/ Challenges

- **Personal Data Exposure** due to technical vulnerabilities.
- **Privacy Concerns - Violation of Article 21**
- **Cybersecurity Risk** - Vulnerabilities can reduce trust in digital governance platforms.
- Weaknesses in security **reduce the trust of public** with government initiatives

What Needs to Be Done ?

- Stronger security audits.
- Timely **vulnerability testing** & patching.
- **Encryption of sensitive data.**
- Access control and authentication strengthening.
- Independent cybersecurity review.
- Better compliance with data protection principles.

Use this in conclusion - Digital governance must be built not only on accessibility and scale, but also on privacy, cybersecurity and institutional accountability

With 4 new benches, how SC plans to clear oldest pending cases

Vineet Bhalla

New Delhi, July 13

TO TACKLE the mounting backlog of cases in the Supreme Court, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has, in a significant move, created four specific benches exclusively to hear the oldest pending civil and criminal matters. This marks a structured attempt to ensure the conclusion of decades-old disputes pending before the apex court.

The new roster

Two division benches, headed by Justices P K Mishra and S V N Bhatti and comprising two judges each, will focus solely on the oldest civil cases. Two other division benches, led by Justices Manoj Misra and Ujjal Bhuyan, will be dedicated solely to the oldest criminal matters.

These special benches will operate on “non-miscellaneous days”, namely Tuesdays, Wednesdays and Thursdays. In the Supreme Court’s parlance, Mondays and Fridays are “miscellaneous days” reserved for fresh filings and preliminary hearings. The middle of the week is meant for “regu-

lar matters” that require detailed, lengthy arguments. By freeing these four benches from the regular burden of miscellaneous hearings, the court will be able to give uninterrupted judicial attention to its longest pending cases.

Scale of the backlog

Data from the National Judicial Data Grid reveals that the Supreme Court currently has 96,045 pending cases. Civil matters make up most of this burden, standing at 74,244 cases, while criminal matters account for the remaining 21,801.

Within this backlog, there are 24 civil cases and two criminal cases that have been pending before the court for over 30 years. The oldest civil case has been pending since 1986, while the oldest criminal case was registered in 1991.

Pendency paradox

This growing backlog presents a productivity paradox. Over the last five years, the Supreme Court has actually increased its rate of clearing cases, picking up markedly from the pandemic years —

Waiting for decades

- About 525 pending civil cases and seven criminal cases were registered between 1996 and 2005.

- The bulk of the older backlog lies in the 10- to 20-year bracket, at 7,993 civil cases and 1,585 criminal cases.

when courts operated at reduced functioning — to record its best-ever disposal figures. However, the overall pendency figure has continued to rise.

This is primarily because the rate of new case intake is outpacing the rate of disposal. With the court becoming more accessible to citizens nationwide through e-filing and virtual hearings, case intake has risen exponentially. In 2025 alone, the total number of cases filed reached an unprecedented 75,402.

Shift in strategy

Different Chief Justices have deployed varying strategies to unclog the docket over the last few years. Former CJI U U Lalit, during his short tenure in 2022, introduced a rigorous listing mechanism that carved out distinct time slots for fresh matters and long-pending regular hearings to ensure that old cases did not get buried under new filings.

Under his successor CJI D Y Chandrachud the court launched the SC-JUDICARE project to automate the classification of pending cases and group matters with

similar legal issues so they could be heard together. He also constituted special benches for specific categories, such as death penalty references, and organised a Special Lok Adalat week to clear cases.

Following him, former CJI Sanjiv Khanna shifted the focus toward “admission matters” – fresh cases that often clog the system before they are even admitted for detailed arguments. For this, he temporarily halted the listing of older regular matters on Wednesdays and Thursdays. He also tasked the court’s Centre for Research and Planning with identifying short, infertile and old matters, successfully weeding out thousands of such cases.

However, during the subsequent tenure of former CJI B R Gavai, a massive surge in new filings pushed the total pendency past the 90,000 mark, despite the bench functioning at high capacity.

Upon taking office towards the end of November 2025, CJI Kant had said that reducing pendency and formulating a unified national policy for disposing of pending matters would be among his top priorities.

Context

The Supreme Court has constituted four special benches to exclusively hear its oldest pending civil and criminal cases

Key Features

- Four Dedicated Special Benches: **Two division** benches will exclusively hear the oldest **civil cases**, while **two** others will focus solely on long-pending **criminal matters**.
- The special benches will function on Tuesdays, Wednesdays and Thursdays.
- **Focus on Legacy Cases:** Priority will be given to decades-old disputes, including **civil cases pending since 1986** and **criminal matters dating back to 1991**.

Potential Benefits

- Higher disposal capacity
- More Division Benches and Constitution Benches
- **Faster hearing of pending cases** (more than 5 crore pending cases)
- Better **access to justice**
- **Opportunity to improve women's representation on the Bench** (less than 5% are women)

Key Concerns

- Court delays are not caused only by a shortage of judges.
- Too many Special Leave Petitions (A Special Leave Petition (SLP) is a legal mechanism in India that allows an aggrieved party to request special permission to appeal to the Supreme Court against a judgment or order from any lower court or tribunal.) increase the Supreme Court's workload.
- A large number of government cases add to the backlog of pending cases. (Around **55% of all pending cases are related to government**)

Way Forward

- **Dismiss fake or baseless cases** at an early stage to save the court's time.
- Give **priority to important constitutional issues** that affect the whole country.
- Implement **strong Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) includes methods like negotiation, mediation,**
- **Imprisonment** for those who bring up with **fake cases**

SC questions the misuse of POCSO in teen relationships

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday questioned the invocation of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act against teenagers involved in voluntary sexual relationships.

A Bench of Justices B.V. Nagarathna and R. Mahadevan observed that parents often resort to criminal proceedings to protect their so-called “honour” when teenage girls elope with their partners.

“How can the state prevent the elopement of a girl and a boy? POCSO concerns the sexual assault and exploitation of children,” the court observed.

The court asked if relationships between those in the age group of 15-18 attracted the penal provisions of the POCSO Act. “It is the age of experimentation,” the Bench said.

The top court made the observation while hearing a *suo motu* case concerning the right to privacy of adolescents. The case had been initiated after Calcutta High Court’s controversial ruling of 2023, which called for adolescent girls to “control” their sexual urges instead of getting entangled in relationships.

Context

The Supreme Court has raised serious concerns about growing misuse of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act 2012.

What is the POCSO Act?

- The POCSO Act was India's first comprehensive law focused solely on **preventing and punishing sexual crimes against children.**

Key provisions include

- **Definition of Child:** Any person below the age of 18 years.
- **Gender Neutrality:** Protecting both male and female children from any gender.
- **Age of Consent:** Explicitly set at 18 years, criminalizing all sexual activity below this age, **regardless of consent between minors.**
- **Confidentiality of Identity:** Forbids disclosure of the victim's identity in any media without court authorization.
- **Time-Bound Trials:** Mandates completion of investigation within two months and trial within one year from FIR registration

Reasons Behind the Alleged Misuse of the POCSO Act

- Since the law treats anyone under 18 as a child, even **consensual** physical relationships between teenagers are criminalized. **Parents** often file cases out of disapproval, especially in **inter-caste, inter-religious, or elopement scenarios**.
- In **bitter divorces** or custody battles, one parent may use POCSO allegations to discredit the other or **influence court decisions for Child custody**.
- **Personal or financial motives**- False accusations are sometimes used for revenge, property disputes, or extortion.
- Many individuals, including adolescents **lack adequate understanding of the POCSO Act's provisions**

Consequences of Misuse

- Those **falsely charged face arrest, social stigma, mental trauma**, and financial strain, even if eventually acquitted.
- **Impact on genuine victims**: Misuse erodes trust in the law, making it harder for real victims to seek justice.
- **Impact on the justice system**: False cases **overload courts** and delay genuine ones.

Way Forward

- **Legal and sexual education** in schools can help adolescents understand consent and consequences.
- **Police officers need better training to identify false** or motivated cases and handle genuine ones with sensitivity.
- **Strict action against false complaints**
- **Parliament and courts should release guidelines for consensual adolescent relationships.**
- Both alleged victims and accused individuals should have access to **professional counseling and legal support.**

Unsafe practices

Safety protocols should not be given short shrift in tourism and adventure

Survivor accounts of the Vietnam boat tragedy last week point to two clearly identifiable contributors. As the weather turned rough and the speedboat took a sharp turn, it tilted to the left. The passengers – all Indian tourists – sitting on the right fell to the left side. Almost all the passenger weight shifted at once, the boat lost balance and turned turtle. As it capsized, the boat captain and guide escaped through the open front door. Others who found an opening also jumped out. Those who could not leave were trapped inside the capsized boat and took in water. Rescuers pulled them ashore where first aid and resuscitation were attempted before they were moved to hospital. All this took precious time and casualties mounted as a result. Some 15 Indians are reported to have died while 17 survived. Four Vietnamese crew also survived. The Indians on the speedboat at Phú Quốc were among more than 100 employees that a mobile company had taken to Vietnam on a corporate incentive tour.

Industry data indicate that some three crore Indians visit foreign countries every year, with a significant proportion of them coming from non-metro cities. Many of the survivors at Phú Quốc were from such cities. South-East Asia has emerged as the preferred destination, with Thailand and Vietnam joining the traditional attractions of Singapore and Malaysia. Many of these new tourist spots are developing rapidly but, like India, have not fully strengthened safety-of-life practices. For instance, just as in India, pleasure boats operators may carry enough life jackets or distribute them but often do not insist that every passenger wears one. Life jackets keep people afloat with their heads above water if they end up in the sea. In Phú Quốc, passengers were reportedly given life jackets, but it is not yet confirmed whether they were all made to wear them before departure. Another basic safety feature should be ensuring that passengers remain securely strapped to their seats so that they do not shift during rough weather or sharp manoeuvres. Even small shifts in passenger weight can significantly affect the stability of a speedboat. This norm was violated in Phú Quốc. Vietnam in particular has witnessed a surge in tourism, with Indians forming a substantial share of visitors. Speedboat rides between the islets of the Phú Quốc archipelago and the main island are especially popular among Indian tourists. The Vietnamese government has promised to review safety standards on such boats and upgrade them where necessary. But Indians, aided by governments and operators, must strengthen their awareness of safety practices, especially those related to fire and water safety.



India-Vietnam

- Vietnam is situated along the **eastern coast of the Indochina Peninsula** in Southeast Asia, sharing land borders with **China to the north, and Laos and Cambodia to the west**. And have a highly strategic coastline along the **South China Sea**.
- Politically, Vietnam is a **single-party socialist republic** where the Communist Party of Vietnam holds exclusive leadership, transformed economically by the **1986 Doi Moi** reforms into an **export-led market economy**.
- Bilateral relations between India and Vietnam were elevated to a **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in 2016**, Vietnam serves as a vital pillar of India's **Act East Policy** and a key partner in its broader Indo-Pacific vision
- India and Vietnam actively collaborate within major regional frameworks, including the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (**ASEAN**) and **Mekong-Ganga Cooperation**

Mekong-Ganga Cooperation (MGC)

The Mekong-Ganga Cooperation (MGC) is a regional initiative launched in **2000** in Vientiane. It comprises **six** member countries: **India, Cambodia, Laos, Myanmar, Thailand, and Vietnam**. The grouping focuses on enhancing **economic, cultural, and educational ties** while fostering closer collaboration in tourism, transport, and communications

ASEAN

The 11 Member States: Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Brunei, Vietnam, Laos, Myanmar, Cambodia, and Timor-Leste

Headquarters- Jakarta, Indonesia

Prelims pyq

Consider the following statements:

- 1. Vietnam has been one of the fastest growing economies in the world in the recent years.**
- 2. Vietnam is led by a multi-party political system.**
- 3. Vietnam's economic growth is linked to its integration with global supply chains and focus on exports.**
- 4. For a long time Vietnam's low labour costs and stable exchange rates have attracted global manufacturers.**
- 5. Vietnam has the most productive e-service sector in the Indo-Pacific region.**

Which of the statements given above are correct?

This question was previously asked in
UPSC Civil Services Exam Offic...

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1. 2 and 4

2. 3 and 5

3. 1, 3 and 4

4. 1 and 2

Is the undocumented migrant counted?

Evidence using official Census data suggest that there is no surge of undocumented migrants from Bangladesh, at least between 1991 and 2011

DATA POINT

Abhishek Shaw

Can India's official statistics detect large-scale undocumented migration? Undocumented migrants may evade law, but can they evade the Census? If millions of them are living in India, they must appear somewhere in the country's official statistics. Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs Kiren Rijiju told Parliament that "As per available inputs, there are around 20 million illegal Bangladeshi migrants staying in India". Then, they must come across enumerators during the Census. What might an undocumented migrant do in such an encounter?

They can respond in three ways: avoid or duck the Census altogether, contributing to coverage error; be counted but report India rather than Bangladesh as the place of birth, creating measurement error; or report the place of birth truthfully.

Each of these choices leaves a different mark in the data, which can be checked. Together, this provides a simple framework for asking whether India's official data are consistent with the claimed scale of undocumented migration. But a framework based on birthplace has a built-in limit: the Census records where a person was born, not whether they entered legally. The same "born in Bangladesh" category contains citizens, visa-holders, and the undocumented alike, with nothing to tell them apart. What the data can speak to, then, is scale: whether a population of the claimed size exists at all.

Ducking

Ducking is hiding from the enumerator altogether. But hiding is not the only way to duck. A subtler version, for example, is to tell the enumerator "I don't actually live here; I will be counted at my usual residence elsewhere" and then not to be counted at that other place

either. The outcome is the same: an omission, which is exactly what the Census is built to detect via the Post Enumeration Survey (PES). This has been conducted after every Census to estimate coverage error and reasons for measurement errors.

The 2011 PES finds a net omission of 23 persons per 1,000 nationally, or 2.3%, unchanged from 2001 (up from 1.8% in 1991). The Eastern zone, with States bordering Bangladesh and where "infiltration" claim is concentrated, is best covered (Table 1). What can be said confidently is that the population missed by enumeration is small, stable across the decades and smallest at the border. This leaves little room for the unenumerated population of the scale the political claim requires.

Misreporting

The second option—being enumerated but recording one's birthplace as India rather than abroad—is the one that costs the least and can be neither verified nor refuted at the point of enumeration. But it has an implication: a person who misreports is still a person the Census has counted. This is what would be termed measurement error. They remain in the total population, in the count by religion, and in the age and sex tables, but the birthplace entry is false.

If, for example, large numbers of undocumented Muslim migrants were doing this, the effect would not be a hidden population but an inflated one—a Muslim population, and with a rate of population growth larger than natural increase and differential fertility can account for—and concentrated in the border districts. That inflation has been examined in an earlier article in *The India Forum*, which found no such signature. If misreporting were hiding a large migrant inflow, it would surface as border-concentrated Muslim growth beyond what fertility explains. The counts showed growth that is moderate, fertility-consis-

tent, and geographically dispersed instead.

Truthful Responses

The third option is to report their place of birth truthfully with the belief that the Census enumeration is anonymous and does not put them at risk. Migrant stock is a widely used measure to keep track of levels of migration. A person enumerated in India, but born in another country is considered a migrant in this measure.

The composition of the migrant stock in India has seen substantial declines of those born in Bangladesh and Pakistan, with large increases in that of Nepal (Chart 1). However, despite decline in overall migrant stock, about half of India's has consistently been Bangladesh-born persons.

In the last three Censuses, roughly 94% of all India's Bangladesh-born residents lived in the five border States (West Bengal, Assam, Tripura, Meghalaya, and Mizoram); a share that barely moved even as the national Bangladesh-born population itself fell by nearly one-third from about 4.0 million to 2.7 million.

Table 2 shows data from districts in the Eastern States bordering Bangladesh. Both by share and by absolute numbers across these districts, migrants who are overwhelmingly from Bangladesh are ageing and likely dying out. The younger age-groups show meagre numbers. Much of this population arrived during Partition in 1947 or the Bangladesh War in 1971. That generation is now elderly, and its numbers are falling chiefly because its members are dying.

Thus, the evidence using official data, in all its forms, suggest that there is no surge of undocumented migrants from Bangladesh, at least between 1991 and 2011.

The Census cannot tell us there are no undocumented migrants from Bangladesh. What it does tell, as checked in three different ways above, is that there are not 20 million of them.

Exaggerated claim

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TABLE 1:

This shows the net omission rates in each of the six zones (as defined by Census) in 2011

Zone	Net Omission Rate (%)	Undercount in 2011 (millions)	Percentage of Undercount
Central	4.17	12.78	46.6%
Northern	3.8	6.07	22.1%
Southern	1.5	3.8	13.8%
Eastern	0.84	2.2	8%
Western	1.17	2.02	7.4%
Northeast	1.24	0.57	2.1%
India	2.3	27.67	100%

CHART 1:

This shows the share of people, whose place of birth was not India, counted in the last three Census

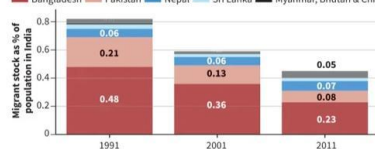


TABLE 2: This shows the number of people in different age groups and their share in total migrant stock in the districts in Eastern States bordering Bangladesh

Age group	2001		2011	
	No of people	% share in total migrant stock	No of people	% share in total migrant stock
0-4 years	2,699	0.2	1,982	0.18
5-9 years	7,348	0.55	3,467	0.31
10-14 years	22,991	1.71	7,030	0.63
15-24 years	72,081	5.35	38,340	3.41
25-34 years	1,42,446	10.58	81,108	7.21
35-59 years	6,48,416	48.14	5,01,655	44.62
60+	4,50,958	33.48	4,90,709	43.65
Total	13,46,939	100	11,24,291	100

Migration in India

<u>TYPE OF MIGRATION</u>	<u>SHARE</u>	<u>Major Reason</u>
Rural to Rural	55%	Marriage
Rural to Urban	19%	Poverty, Employment, Education
Urban to Urban	16%	Better jobs/ career growth
Urban to Rural	10%	Retirement life

Migration in India, 2020-21" report by
National Sample Survey Office (NSSO)

Thank you